



Naked aggression: Virat Kohli's century and battle with Mitchell Johnson in Melbourne spiced up India's 2014 tour Down Under. AP

unreal the way he took on the responsibility of thinking for every member of the team.

Virat was the most reassuring presence for newcomers, a captain who stood firmly behind his players. The way he backed them, especially in difficult moments, drew out their best. Players embraced his leadership with the same trust and enthusiasm once reserved for MS Dhoni.

Virat was, in every sense, a player's captain — giving everything he had, and expecting nothing less from those around him. His handling of the Mohammed Shami episode exemplifies how he stood up for his teammate when the fast bowler was

subjected to unfair social media trolling after the 10-wicket loss to Pakistan in the 2021 T20 World Cup.

I can rate Virat the best batsman of the modern era. **A complete batsman who came to eliminate his flaws and turn them into assets on the pitch.** At one stage of his career, his average across all three formats was 50-plus. What a phenomenal figure he was in world cricket. You had to see the joy enveloping his opponents when they saw his back. Getting Virat's wicket was a throwback to when the opponents

were assured of a comfortable position on getting the scalps of Gavaskar and Tendulkar.

Do you remember how he rebuilt himself for England? He must have doubted his credentials after the nightmare tour of 2014 (134 runs in five Tests). Four years later, he returned to conquer. He toyed with the English attack (593 runs in five Tests). On his way to that long-awaited century on English soil, he walked the tightrope between restraint and radiance at Edgbaston. He tamed James Anderson —

« Mental fatigue may have driven his decision to retire from Tests, even though he was as fit as any other player in the team »